Social structure of Indus Valley Civilization

S.K.Venkatesan
CQRL Bits, Chennai

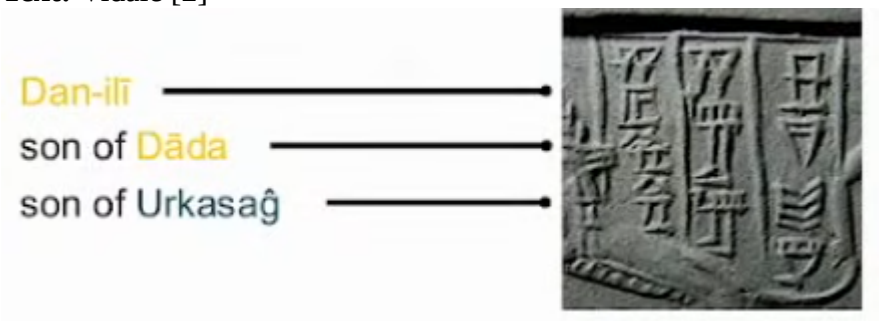
We briefly study the social strata of Indus Valley Civilization (IVC) as obtained from the insight offered by Dravidian decipherment of the author [1] and as well through the various material artifacts unearthed [2, 3].

Seal from Bactria Afghanistan

Source: Vidale [2]
Text: 𒌋: 𒄀𒌋𒄀𒌋: ūril-uvan-uḷḷavan
Semantics: The town's food provider, the all-powerful rich man.
This is a commentary on inequality by an IVC person on Bactria, Afghanistan.

Sumeria vs Meluko (Indus) skirmish

Source: Boehmer [3]
Semantics: This is an encounter between Indus and Sumeria (in the bordering forest region), Indus being depicted by the bull (muri, marru: barter trader denoted by bull, meluko – region of raised forts) and Sumeria by the Lion (urumu, Lion king).
Text: Vidale [2]



From Indus decipherment [1]:
𒀭𒀭 – an-an – annan – elder brother – 𒀭𒌆 – ūran – town-head – ūr-sag (Sumerian)

Indus internal skirmish and resolution

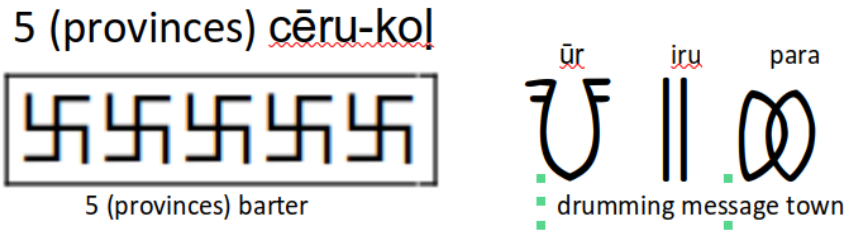
Text: 𒁹𒌋𒌋𒌋 𒌋𒌋𒌋, taḷu-utai
Semantics: Push-kick (skirmish)

Text: ‖ 𐌂𐌺𐌼𐌰, cēru-koṭṭu-tam-ar
Semantics: Fighting among themselves

Text: 𐌺𐌿𐌼𐌹𐌺𐌰𐌺𐌰𐌽𐌽𐌹𐌰𐌽𐌿𐌿𐌿, kuru-vilaku-ar-kanni-anuppu
Semantics: Send for dispute solver

Semantics: Reports the atrocities in bull province on women/people.
Analogy: Picasso's Guernica:

Communication system of drummers



Barter and marriage between provinces

(cira-kompu-)māṟan(-kulampu)-koḷal

Semantics: barter exchange

cēṟukoḷ cēṟi+koḷal

Semantics: join together (barter)

valaiyan-ūr.il ai-naṭṭu uṭaṉ-ñāṇ

Semantics: Five-province marriage event in trapper's town

Conclusions

Indus Civilization is no egalitarian paradise, as it has it's fair share of disputes, policing and statecraft. On the other hand, it is not an oppressive system of kings and temple priests as in the Sumerian or Elamite civilizations or probably as oppressive as in the Bronze age Bactria BMAC. The class structure in IVC was a nascent form of class system with chieftains of professions, town and provinces with horned head gear, but they had bangles and hair-locks like women, with a social system that has not degraded the status of women to the extent as in the later societies. This is exemplified by the bronze statue of confident working class women standing with her hand supporting her slender hip. However, the first class division, that between men and women, has come about, with men as the ruling chieftains with horned head gear, with the policing of disputes and distribution of food being taken care by bowman of different kinds (vilōn, vilampan) and the bartering being mediated by an expert professional (cira-kompu-māran-kulampu). A system of messaging by highly respected drummers (paraiar) is organized as the main backbone of the IVC communication system that encourages towns and provinces to exchange goods as well as arrange a system of mass marriages. The Swastika symbol (deciphered as cerukol – join together), being like the Da Vinci Code, the magical word that calls for the mixing of people across clans, towns and provinces.

References

[1] Venkatesan, S.K., (2025) Decipherment of Indus Valley Script, https://github.com/Sukii/decipher-ivc

[2] Vidale, M., (2026) New insights on the Urban phase of the Indus Valley tradition, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Xv_6aZEpj9Q

[3] Boehmer, R.M., (1965) *Die Entwicklung der Glyptik während der Akkad-Zeit*, De Gruyter, Berlin